CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Thursday, November 12, 2026

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RE: Wale says broken climate pledges 'ought to be criminal' · Nauru left with no opposition · $80m for AUKUS workforce · Guterres presses Australia at COP31 · Kiribati wants faster fund access

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
9,147	0.6835	14,259	0.5567
+0.90%	-1.39%	+2.48%	-0.52%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · AUKUS · Pacific · New Zealand · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Solomon Islands Prime Minister Matthew Wale told COP31 that donors' unmet climate finance pledges "ought to be criminal" and urged Pacific states to stop being too humble.
2. Nauru's parliament has no opposition after every MP joined the government, a step the government called "a truly historic moment".
3. Canberra committed more than $80 million to expand AUKUS training pathways as COP31 delegates pressed Australia on its fossil fuel exports.

TOP STORIES

AUKUS

Canberra adds $80 million to the AUKUS workforce pipeline

More than *$80 million* will go to growing the workforce needed to deliver AUKUS, expanding training pathways across the country. The investment is pitched at Australians at all stages of their careers, not only school leavers entering apprenticeships. Workforce supply has been the recurring constraint cited in submarine build and sustainment planning.

per SMH: "Over 80 million to be spent on growing Australia's workforce to deliver AUKUS"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Guterres tells COP31 fossil fuels must go "the way of the dinosaurs"

Outgoing UN Secretary-General **António Guterres** told world leaders at COP31 that "fossil fuels must go the way of the dinosaurs". **Anthony Albanese** responded by defending Australia as a climate leader after being pushed on the world stage to do more. Pacific advocates at the summit have criticised what they call a noticeable omission of fossil fuel phase-out plans from Australia's position.

per SMH Federal Politics (Natassia Chrysanthos): "Albanese defends Australia as climate leader after being pushed on world stage to do more" · also ABC Pacific

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Solomon Islands PM says broken climate pledges "ought to be criminal"

Solomon Islands Prime Minister **Matthew Wale** used COP31 in Antalya to attack the world's biggest polluters, saying their failure to honour climate finance pledges "ought to be criminal". He told Pacific delegations they must stop being too humble in pressing wealthy states. Wale chaired the Pacific Islands Forum through 2026 before the chair passed to Palau.

per PNG Post-Courier (Gorethy Kenneth): "Wale: Broken Climate Pledges ought to be criminal, Pacific must stop being too humble"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Nauru's parliament is left without an opposition

Every member of Nauru's parliament has joined the government, the country announced in a statement on Tuesday, leaving no formal opposition in the chamber. The government described the move as "a truly historic moment". Nauru's last recorded entry in this brief's China ledger was the Forum's September statement on missile testing.

per RNZ Pacific: "No opposition left in Naoero after all MPs join government"

OVERNIGHT

TRADE-ECONOMY

ASIC sues Commonwealth Bank over alleged business customer overcharging · Reuters

Australia's corporate watchdog has launched proceedings against Commonwealth Bank over allegations it overcharged business customers. The case follows ASIC's formal probe into the $2.3 billion Bathla collapse opened earlier this month and adds to a crowded enforcement docket against the country's largest lender.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Australian dollar falls to its lowest level since January · Bloomberg

The Australian dollar dropped to its weakest since January, trading at *0.6835*, down 1.39 percent, which Bloomberg attributes to expectations of a slower Reserve Bank and fears over artificial intelligence valuations. The AFR reports the slide risks feeding imported price pressure and complicating the inflation fight, with the cash rate at 4.35 percent.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Thunberg says Australia moves on climate at the pace of a snail · AFR

Greta Thunberg condemned Australia's record on emissions cuts at COP31, saying "even a snail would agree" the country is too slow. Her appearance drew more than 100 reporters and supporters before security escorted her out, according to the Sydney Morning Herald.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Megaspeed's links to a rural Australian store raise fresh Nvidia questions · Reuters

Reuters has traced links between Megaspeed, the firm at the centre of the Nvidia chip diversion scandal, and a rural Australian retail address. The Australian reports separately that Australian super funds are examining the safety of $6 billion in Nvidia holdings as congressional Republicans prepare to subpoena the chipmaker's chief executive.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Australian employers face "AI washing" claims after a wave of job cuts · Reuters

Australian companies are being accused of AI washing, invoking artificial intelligence to justify redundancies and offshoring, Reuters reports. The claims follow Canva's cut of 1,271 roles and Qantas's plan to move 850 corporate jobs to Accenture.

STAT OF THE DAY

93.1 billion vatu

Vanuatu's national budget just passed by parliament

Finance Minister Johnny Koanapo said the government must balance revenue demands against cost-of-living relief, including possible tax changes on basic food items.

ABC Pacific

AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 1 · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Magazine makes the case for Western Australian infrastructure in defence plans

Australian Defence Magazine argues Western Australian infrastructure is critical to Defence's plans, the state hosting both HMAS Stirling and the Henderson precinct. USS Colorado arrived at Stirling for a maintenance period on November 6.

PILLAR 1 · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

United States maintenance experience applied to Australian submarine work

Australian Defence Magazine reports on American submarine maintenance practice being transferred into Australian sustainment work, the skills pathway that the new $80 million workforce package is intended to widen.

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

Industry guide walks through navigating export controls

Australian Defence Magazine sets out how firms are navigating export controls, the licensing terrain that governs defence trade between the three AUKUS partners and determines which technologies move freely.

PACIFIC WIRE

KIRIBATI · RNZ PACIFIC

Kiribati minister seeks immediate access to climate funds

Kiribati's Women, Youth, Sport and Social Affairs Minister **Ruth Cross Kwansing** proposed a model letting small island developing states start urgent adaptation projects immediately under the Green Climate Fund and Adaptation Fund, rather than build a new institution. She said women, children, the elderly and people with disabilities are hit hardest by delay.

TONGA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tonga pushes climate-resilient schools into the COP31 finance debate

Tonga is pressing for stronger investment in climate-resilient schools and education systems at the COP31 talks in Türkiye. The pitch puts education infrastructure alongside coastal protection in the list of adaptation priorities Pacific delegations are carrying to Antalya.

NIUE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Niue's ocean conservation model attracts international investment

Niue's model for financing long-term ocean conservation is drawing international investors, with more than half its conservation commitment covered, Islands Business reports. Niue is taking the model to COP31 as evidence that Pacific stewardship can be made bankable.

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

El Niño dry spell cuts Cook Islands harvests

Taro and leafy vegetable yields are falling as a prolonged El Niño dry spell bites, with growers following water-saving guidelines issued after Cook Islands Meteorological Service forecasts. Te Tango Enua growers' association president **Danny Mataroa** warned of higher prices and greater reliance on imported produce.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Vanuatu weighs tax changes on basic food items as living costs climb

Finance Minister **Johnny Koanapo** told parliament the government is discussing its tax regime, including tax on basic food items in stores, while balancing revenue demands under the *93.1 billion vatu* national budget parliament has passed. He was answering a question from Tafea Outer Islands member Tomker Netvunei.

TIMOR-LESTE · ABC PACIFIC

Timor-Leste marks 35 years since the Santa Cruz massacre

Indonesian soldiers opened fire on unarmed protesters at the Santa Cruz cemetery in Dili on November 12, 1991, killing around 250 people. **Maria Angelina Lopes Sarmento**, then 13 and now a member of the National Parliament, said independence "is the beginning of all the struggles, including the struggle to recognise dignity".

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC

PNG floats a three-child cap per family

The Papua New Guinea government may cap the number of children a family can have at three, RNZ Pacific correspondent **Johnny Blades** reported. The same segment notes large parts of the Pacific battling a water crisis under extremely dry El Niño conditions.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Maladina backs independent audit of Papua LNG Forum funds

Petroleum Minister **Jimmy Maladina** welcomed the National Petroleum Authority board's decision to commission an independent audit of funds allocated and spent on the Papua LNG Development Forum. "It must proceed without interference to establish the facts," he said, ordering reconciliation within 48 hours.

FIJI · FBC NEWS

Fiji's election bodies defend new ballot counting centres

The Electoral Commission and Fijian Elections Office acknowledged civil society concerns about amendments to the Electoral Act 2014, in particular the new section 9A providing for ballots to be counted at commission-approved counting centres. Both bodies said they welcome scrutiny of the change.

FIJI · FBC NEWS

Biman Prasad acquitted in FICAC disclosure case

The Suva Magistrates Court acquitted former Deputy Prime Minister and National Federation Party leader **Biman Prasad** in the case brought by the Fiji Independent Commission Against Corruption, upholding a no-case-to-answer application after submissions.

REGIONAL · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

US House passes veterans healthcare expansion covering COFA states

The House passed the Take Care of America's Veterans Act, H.R. 9237, with two provisions expanding healthcare access for veterans in US territories and the freely associated states. CNMI Delegate **Kimberlyn King-Hinds** said there was no better way to mark Veterans Day.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

Solomon Islands displacement documentary heads to COP31

Solwata, a virtual reality documentary narrated by **Mark Ruffalo**, follows the Walande, Ngongosila and Kwai communities of Malaita Province. Human Rights Watch researcher **Erica Bower** said of Walande, a community of about 800 people: "Today, their island no longer exists."

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand bond auction demand hits its highest since 2013

Demand at a New Zealand government bond auction climbed to its strongest level since 2013, Bloomberg reports, as investors move into sovereign paper while coalition formation talks continue after the November 7 election. Unemployment rose ahead of that vote.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

SMH says the "Albo" persona has stopped working

Four years into the prime ministership, the goodwill behind **Anthony Albanese**'s self-presentation as "Albo" has worn off, the Sydney Morning Herald argues. The Resolve Political Monitor put voter trust in the prime minister at 20 percent on November 9.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

One Nation's Victorian leader says taxpayers should not prop up a "bankrupt" state

One Nation's state leader told Politico that Australians should not have to prop up a "bankrupt" Victoria, turning the state's finances into a federal transfer argument weeks out from the Victorian election. Victorian Labor fell to third place behind One Nation in polling published on November 9.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Students walk out of class to protest One Nation

Students in several Australian cities walked out of classrooms on Thursday afternoon to protest Pauline Hanson's One Nation and its policies. Organiser **Odessa Bishop-McMurray**, 18, said the action targets the normalisation of far-right politics, part of what researchers call a resurgence of activism among those aged 14 to 29.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Meta takes down the Australian Femicide Watch page

Meta has shut down the page tracking the murder of women in Australia, and founder **Sherele Moody** has demanded its reinstatement. The removal lands while the government is legislating new online safety obligations and preparing to stand up an AI safety regulator.

AU-DEFENSE · ABC NEWS

No answers on remediation of a contaminated Defence site before hand-back

Defence has not said whether a contaminated site at Stokes Hill Wharf in Darwin will be remediated before it is handed back, the ABC reports. The question follows the government's decision to scrap the sale of four heritage defence sites.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

BHP plans an overhaul of its Australian iron ore business

BHP will restructure its Australian iron ore operations to cut costs, Bloomberg reports, as the miner also names its Australian projects boss as the next chief financial officer. Iron ore remains Australia's largest single export earner.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Another Australian data centre halts as public backlash grows

A second data centre project has stopped amid rising public opposition, Bloomberg reports, days after the Conservation Council sought a moratorium on data centres in the ACT. AirTrunk has separately signed a renewables supply deal for an Australian facility.

TRADE-ECONOMY · POLITICO

PsiQuantum chief says "nothing has changed" in its Australia plans

PsiQuantum's chief executive insisted the company's Australian plans are intact despite delays, Politico reports. The Brisbane quantum computer is the largest single commitment under the government's critical technologies agenda and a Pillar 2 adjacent capability.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FBC NEWS

Fiji Airways offers voluntary separation packages

Fiji Airways is offering voluntary early retirement and separation agreements to cut operating costs during the prolonged global fuel crisis, chief executive **Paul Scurrah** told FBC News. The exercise mainly targets middle management, management and non-operational staff, with no set headcount target.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

COMMUNIQUE · FIJI SUN

Pacific tells COP31: no more empty promises

Pacific delegations issued a collective demand at COP31 for delivery on existing commitments rather than new pledges, framed around finance access and loss and damage. The message aligns with Kiribati's call for immediate disbursement and Tonga's push on education financing.

UPCOMING

NOV 2026

COP31 concludes in Antalya, Türkiye

Pacific delegations are pressing for faster climate finance access and a fossil fuel phase-out text that Australia has so far resisted.

NOV 2026

Victorian state election

One Nation's standing in Victoria and Chinese-Australian voting blocs in Melbourne's east will shape federal Coalition positioning.

NOV 2026

Independent audit of Papua LNG Development Forum funds begins

The audit tests governance of PNG's largest resource project at a moment of donor scrutiny over Pacific aid delivery.

JAN 2027

New US Congress convenes with Democratic majorities

Committee control determines the pace of Virginia-class authorisation work and any AI inquiry that touches Australian firms.

THE WIRE

CHINA-PACIFIC

LOWY INTERPRETER

The climate card China has yet to play

As Washington closes visa pathways for Pacific islanders, Beijing has money, technology and experience to offer new ones, the Interpreter argues.

AU-DEFENSE

ASPI STRATEGIST

Fault Lines: China's navy mobilises, Marines in Manila, PNG's LNG

ASPI's fortnightly Defence Strategy Program survey covers the period from 30 October 2026, tracking Chinese naval activity, the US Marine presence in the Philippines and PNG's gas sector.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

What are Australia's offshore university campuses for?

Soft power or revenue raising: overseas campuses will not build ties without a public purpose, the Interpreter argues.

SMH WORLD

Turnbull defends the $32,000 COP coffee cart

Former prime minister **Malcolm Turnbull** says free coffee at the Australian pavilion is a strong marketing tool at a conference drawing close to 100,000 people a year.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

VANUATU DAILY POST

Australia backs expansion of Vanuatu infrastructure planning platform

Australia is supporting the rollout of a digital asset-planning platform across Vanuatu's Ministry of Infrastructure and Public Utilities, aimed at how the country plans, maintains and invests in public infrastructure.

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

ABC PACIFIC

Guam veteran's Medal of Honor upgrade sits with Trump

An assessment upgrading the citation of the late **Juan Ogo Blaz** was signed by Secretary of War **Pete Hegseth** and now awaits President **Donald Trump**. Pacific Centre for Island Security chair **Robert Underwood** said it is rare for such cases to be decided on merit.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

AUSTRALIAN ARMY RESEARCH CENTRE

The Precision Paradox in Defence Acquisition

The Australian Army Research Centre examines how acquisition processes that demand ever finer specification trade speed for certainty. The argument lands as Austal cuts steel on Landing Craft Heavy and Defence expands its submarine workforce spending.

Argument: Greater precision in defence acquisition requirements can slow delivery rather than improve it.

PAUL STRANGIO · INSIDE STORY

What really makes Australia exceptional?

Paul Strangio examines the sources of Australian distinctiveness in Inside Story. The piece runs as polling shows trust in the prime minister at 20 percent and minor parties gaining ground in Victoria.

Argument: Australia's claim to exceptionalism rests on its political institutions rather than its resources or geography.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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